

THE OPPOSITION CHARGE (Left) PM Narendra Modi with Union minister and state BJP president G. Kishan Reddy in Hyderabad, Nov. 7; (below) Congress leaders Rahul Gandhi and Priyanka Gandhi with state party president A. Revanth Reddy in Mulugu district, Oct. 18



forefront of BRS's campaign rallies, he had finished addressing Praja Ashirvada Sabhas (people's blessings rallies) in 36 constituencies before Diwali itself. By the time campaigning ends on November 28, KCR hopes he will cover a staggering 100 constituencies—a daily average of 3-4 rallies—barring just the nine constituencies being contested by the friendly party, AIMIM, or the All-India Majlis-e-Ittehadul Muslimeen.

At his rallies, KCR tries to be as punctual as possible. In his speeches, he dwells on the Telangana growth story, his "struggle and sacrifice for separate statehood", in the hope of appealing to the electorate's emotions. He then focuses on the theme of change with continuity, and better welfare measures and sops before seeking support for his unfinished agenda of taking Telangana from 'Good to Great'—a new slogan he has coined for the party campaign this time. It's a rare political stalwart that has won three terms in a row in the southern states and KCR hopes it will be his crowning achievement when votes are counted on December 3.

To pull off a hat-trick, KCR is relying on political savvy and astute strategy backed by his centralised style of functioning and impressive performance. The party has tasked booth committees to meet their target of 100 voters each to convince them with persistent effort and reasoning to support and vote for the BRS till the last day of campaigning. They explain the work done by the government, what is in the offing and request voters to compare development of their respective areas before 2014 and now.

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On the face of it, KCR seems to have all bases covered. He has even designated constituency in-charges to keep track. But the going will be by no means easy. While acknowledging that the early start will be a major advantage for the BRS candidates, Harathi Vageeshan, who teaches law at the NALSAR University, Hyderabad, says, "the fact that they have nothing new to communicate to the voters, barring in places like Hyderabad, is a disadvantage. Moreover, many BRS MLAs are facing the anger of the people on the ground."

THE CONGRESS REBIRTH

Making KCR's task tougher will be the Congress party, its main rival, which is experiencing a rebirth of sorts in the state. In 2018, the gap in the vote share of the Congress and the Telangana Rashtra Samithi or TRS, as the BRS was called then, was 18.5 percentage points. So, despite the Congress polling 28.4 per cent votes in 2018, higher than the 25.2 per